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# The Popularity Gap: Effects of Social Status on the Visibility of Lifestyle Sports Stars on Instagram

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**Abstract**

Social media provides athletes with opportunities to enhance their personal brands, engage with fans, and access professional opportunities. Several studies have examined how athletes use social media to attract and engage large audiences. Less is known about the social forces that enable and constrain their popularity. Drawing on expectation states theory, this study considers how athletes' social status affects their follower counts and engagement rates on Instagram. Based on a content analysis of 6240 images posted on Instagram by 112 professional disc golfers, we show that the gender, sport dominance, and physical attractiveness of athletes affect their popularity, controlling for their strategic efforts to self-brand. These findings offer new insight into the ongoing debate over social media's impact on long-standing inequalities in the media-sport industry.

**Keywords**

social media, social status, gender, physical attractiveness, popularity

Self-branding is the process of centering the self in social media posts and creating a uniform image for public consumption (Whitmer, 2019). Across the sports world,

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athletes are building their personal brands and expanding their fanbases through social media to market products and services. For some stars of major league sports, social media has now become a source of income that rivals their athletic salaries (Sweney, 2021). The importance of self-branding is even greater for athletes from less-established sports, since social media earnings often account for a greater share of their total income. Lifestyle athletes from a range of disciplines, such as skateboarding (Nichols, 2022), rock climbing (Dumont, 2017), parkour (Gilchrist & Wheaton, 2013), wakeboarding (Parris et al., 2014), and disc golf (Woods, 2021), rely heavily on endorsement deals and related social media marketing opportunities to fund their activities.

Platforms like Instagram, Twitter and Facebook allow athletes greater autonomy to share their experiences and promote their brands without relying on the gatekeepers of traditional media (Benkler, 2006; Hutchins & Rowe, 2013). A diverse pool of athletes and grassroots groups have established influential online networks by attracting and engaging large followings. Given the potential benefits of becoming popular on social media, several scholars have identified self-branding techniques that maximize popularity (Hudders et al., 2021; Sundermann & Raabe, 2019; Vrontis et al., 2021), but less research has investigated the social forces that limit the popularity of social media influencers (SMIs). Popularity is defined here as a user's total number of followers ("reach") and mean number of likes ("engagement") on Instagram.

This study critically examines the extent to which and for whom becoming a popular SMI is achievable. We begin by considering how the rise of social media is affecting the visibility of athletes who have been historically marginalized in traditional media. We then theorize how the social status of SMIs may be related to their popularity online. Based on a content analysis of 6240 images posted on Instagram by 112 professional disc golfers, we show that the popularity of SMIs is predicted by their gender, sport dominance, and attractiveness, net of their strategic efforts to self-brand.

## Theoretical Framework

Top-performing, white male athletes have historically held the dominant position in US sports, with high visibility in traditional media, such as newspapers, television and magazines (Carter-Francique & Richardson, 2016). In the early 21st century, consumer demand for sports websites increased, while social media platforms like Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube thrived. The widespread adoption of new communication technologies and digital media led some scholars to predict a dramatic shift in media portrayals of women in sports and popular culture (Blakley, 2010). Social media offered women athletes and other marginalized groups a direct route to audiences, allowing them to craft their own public images, engage with fans, build their brands, amass large followings, and boost the visibility of their sports (Colapinto & Benecchi 2014; MacPherson & Kerr 2021; Toffoletti et al., 2021). Social media also proved to be a powerful engine for niche community building. The athletes and fans of sports that were once ignored by traditional media could gather on social media, explore their

common interests, reinforce their identities, and develop their lifestyles (Vann, 2014; Woods, 2021). A decentralized, democratized social media sphere would weaken the dominant culture of sport and allow more women and racial minority athletes to become more visible.

While evidence of these new opportunities mounted, some scholars downplayed the differences between traditional and social media (Toffoletti & Thorpe, 2018), and argued that social inequality in various forms was being reproduced online, leaving workers of the digital media marketplace vulnerable to exploitation (Duffy, 2017; Duffy & Pruchniewska, 2017; Faucher, 2018). The purpose of this study is to determine whether (or to what extent) social media perpetuates inequality among lifestyle sports athletes on social media. In the next section, we use expectation states theory to consider how social status may reinforce disparities in the visibility of professional disc golfers on Instagram.

## *Status Characteristics as Predictors of Popularity*

Developed by sociologists and social psychologists in the 1970s, expectation states theory explains how social hierarchies, and the inequalities that go along with them, develop in groups when people rely on the status characteristics of individuals to determine who should become group leaders, who should have the most influence on group outcomes, and ultimately who should have the most power (Berger et al., 1977; Humphreys & Berger, 1981). The theory draws on Bales' (1950) groundbreaking studies of interpersonal behavior in small groups. Initial applications of expectation states theory examine how status characteristics such as race (Webster & Driskell, 1978), gender (Pugh & Wahrman, 1983) and education level (Moore, 1968) influence the emergence of status hierarchies within task settings.

There are two types of status characteristics that guide people's evaluations of others. *Specific status* characteristics carry expectations related to a specific task, such as a basketball player's average points per game. *Diffuse status* characteristics involve general expectations, such as a belief that men are better at sports than women. Specific status is associated with a person's accomplishments, such as education and occupation, whereas diffuse characteristics are ascribed by others and cannot be easily changed, such as gender, race, age, and physical attractiveness.

The expectations people attach to status characteristics are rooted in longstanding cultural beliefs. Correll and Ridgeway (2006) describe status expectation states theory as a "macro-micro-macro" explanation of social inequality: "Cultural beliefs about social categories at the macro level impact behavior and evaluation at the individual level, which acts to reproduce status structures that are consistent with pre-existing macro-level beliefs" (51). Status beliefs can affect people's judgements and behavior through a cognitive process that is automatic and unconscious (Roth, 2004). Beliefs about the superiority or inferiority of certain group members operate like cognitive schemas that foster consensus within groups, both among those who are advantaged and disadvantaged by the given belief (Ridgeway & Bourg, 2004).

The empirical support for expectation states theory is derived primarily from experiments, which allow for precise measurements of status effects and control for extraneous variables (Thye & Kalkhoff, 2009). Our study of the popularity of professional disc golfers is based on a content analysis of Instagram accounts. Such an approach accounts for social media users' decisions to follow and engage certain SMIs, but it cannot speak directly to the reasoning, beliefs, or biases that lead to these decisions. Still, expectation states theory offers a parsimonious framework for considering how multiple forms of inequality emerge in online sports communities.

Across the world of sports, specific status characteristics are clearly tied to athletes' performances in competitions (Guttman, 1978). Aware of various performance metrics, sports fans' beliefs about players' past performances likely shape their expectations about future ones, which may lead to greater popularity on social media for high-ranked athletes than lower-ranked ones. Top players may be expected to perform especially well on some tasks on social media, such as teaching the skills of their sport on YouTube, offering equipment advice on Twitter, or posting entertaining trick-shot videos on Instagram. Considering these task-specific status expectations, players with higher competition ratings are probably more popular than players with lower ratings.

A similar status expectation may also be linked to athletes' relationships with organizations. The effects of relational status have been studied in several social contexts. For instance, workers who graduate from prestigious educational institutions receive advantages in earnings and other benefits, net of their abilities and other known correlates (Jung & Lee, 2016; Long, 2010; Thomas & Zhang, 2005). Although there is less evidence of organizational prestige effects on social media popularity, Jensen et al. (2014) found that the most influential factor explaining the popularity of big-time college football coaches on Twitter was their university's historical level of prestige. In the case of professional disc golf, there are dozens of organizations that manufacturer disc golf equipment (PDGA, 2023). While many of them sponsor professional disc golfers, a small number of top manufacturers sponsor the lion's share of the world's most talented players (see the Method section below). As disc golf enthusiasts consider who to follow on social media, they may use a player's association with a respected company as a heuristic to determine who is worthy of their time.

Physical attractiveness can be conceptualized as a diffuse status characteristic, as it involves at least two states, attractive and unattractive, which are rooted in relatively stable social perceptions, and result in advantages or disadvantages for those who occupy them (Frevert & Walker, 2014; Webster & Driskell, 1983). Several studies have demonstrated that being perceived as physically attractive can affect outcomes in the labor market, criminal justice system, politics, and education (Wolbring & Riordan, 2016; Monk et al., 2021). Beautiful people are perceived as more trustworthy, kinder, smarter, healthier, and less blameworthy for their mistakes than less attractive people (Dion et al., 1972). Some research on the popularity of SMIs has identified attractiveness as a positive predictor of popularity. Wiedmann and von Mettenheim (2020) demonstrated that the attractiveness of SMIs in the fashion industry produced significant effects on brand image, brand trust, and brand satisfaction. Masuda, Han and

Lee (2022) showed that the attractiveness of YouTubers was found to be positively associated with levels of their trustworthiness, perceived expertise, and the formation of parasocial relationships between influencers and followers. In general, the literature suggests that being attractive benefits SMIs in various ways and may boost their popularity (Essi et al., 2019; Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; VonMettenheim & Wiedmann, 2021).

Moving to gender as a status characteristic, many sports fans share a belief that men are more esteemed and competent than women in athletic competitions (Vanzella-Yang & Finger, 2021). If men are perceived as more athletically talented, skilled, or entertaining on the field than women, this could lead to the expectation that men SMIs are more worthy of being followed and engaged with than women SMIs. Status expectations may also lead followers to evaluate the competence of women athletes more harshly than that of men in both face-to-face and online contexts (Foschi, 2000; Ridgeway, 1997). If women are more likely than men to receive criticism and trolling in online spaces, they may avoid social media altogether or become less active than men in the self-branding process (Garcia & Proffitt, 2022; Osborne et al., 2021).

## *Self-Branding*

Status expectation states theory suggests that widely held beliefs, rooted in status hierarchies in the broader society, may provide advantages to sport SMIs who are men, highly ranked, affiliated with prestigious organizations, and physically attractive. To show that these characteristics predict the popularity of SMIs, we must control for the time, effort, and strategies SMIs use to establish a personal brand on social media. Self-branding involves centering the self in social media posts, emphasizing a uniform activity, and building a brand that attracts and engages followers and ultimately leads to the sale of products and services for material gain (Whitmer, 2019). Drawing on a qualitative analysis of athlete SMIs on Instagram, Woods et al. (2023) identified six elements of self-branding behavior, including "player in post" (the player appears in a photo or video), "sport in post" (the player's chosen sport appears in a photo or video), "brand in post" (a company's logo appears in a photo or video), and "product display" (a product is prominently displayed in a photo or video). In addition, Woods et al. (2023) noted the importance of SMIs' total number of posts and years of experience on Instagram as key indicators of the self-branding process.

Although Woods et al. (2023) did not investigate the effects of self-branding, previous research suggests a positive association between self-branding and popularity. SMIs tend to accrue more followers over time, and those who post more often are more popular than those who post less frequently (Ashley & Tuten, 2015; Hopkins, 2013; Jensen et al., 2014; Watanabe et al., 2015). Emphasizing the self in social media posts has been shown to be an effective strategy on some platforms. For instance, in their study of YouTubers, Lee and Theokary (2021) found a positive association between the use of first-person pronouns and their number of views and subscribers. Including a human face in Instagram posts increased the number of comments, per a study by

Yesiloglu and Waskiw (2021). Although some SMIs may feel more comfortable cataloguing the events of their lives from behind a camera, posting images and videos of their faces and bodies, while consistently engaging in a specific sport, likely increases their popularity.

Other elements of self-branding, such as wearing branded clothing and discussing or displaying products in posts, may create an authenticity dilemma for SMIs. Social media posts containing the real-life experiences of SMIs (organic content) tend to be more popular than officially sponsored content and advertisements (Costello & Urbanska, 2021; Lim et al., 2021; Neal, 2018; Zhang & Peng, 2015). However, some research suggests that audiences favor social media content that features the products and services of SMIs and their partners. An SMI's expert advice on a consumer good may be what attracts an audience in the first place. Lim et al. (2021) showed that thoughtful discussions centered on a YouTuber's personal experiences with a product ("the reflective theme") were more engaging than five other video themes. Promoting the products of a prestigious company may increase SMIs' status and likeability and provide them with financial resources to create high-quality content for social media. For these reasons, SMIs who are actively engaged in promoting products and businesses are likely to be more popular than those who rarely feature companies in their posts.

### *Hypotheses*

Based on the research discussed above, we investigated the following hypotheses:

**Hypothesis 1:** Men players are more popular than women players.
**Hypothesis 2:** High-ranked players are more popular than low-ranked players.
**Hypothesis 3:** Players who are sponsored by prestigious companies are more popular than players who are not sponsored by prestigious companies.
**Hypothesis 4:** Self-branding behaviors are positively associated with popularity.
**Hypothesis 5:** Attractive players are more popular than unattractive players.

## Method

### *A Case Study of Professional Disc Golfers*

Disc golf is an outdoor sport and recreational activity where players throw streamlined plastic discs into metal baskets from varying distances. Its popularity began growing rapidly in the 2000s. According to the sport's governing body, the Professional Disc Golf Association (PDGA), between 1999 and 2022, the number of current PDGA members in the US alone increased from 5403 to 103,342, while PDGA events jumped from 329 to 8931. The number of US disc golf courses increased from 851 to 7466 over the same period (PDGA, 2022). Fans were increasingly watching professional tournaments on YouTube and other streaming services, prompting some coverage from

national television networks including CBS and ESPN, as well as interest from large corporate sponsors ((Gardner, 2021; Laws, 2021; Woods, 2021). Given these new commercial opportunities, professional disc golfers are ideal subjects for studying the effects of self-branding on popularity over time. Disc golf is also notable for being one of the few professional sports where men and women compete at the same events, making it suitable for studying gender-based disparities in the reach and engagement of SMIs.

## Sample

We conducted a quantitative content analysis of the Instagram accounts held by the 112 highest ranked professional disc golfers in the world. These subjects were selected based on their inclusion in the Disc Golf World Rankings Index. The index is calculated and updated by Udisc, a company that provides online scorekeeping and statistics for disc golf tournaments (Buursma, 2021). To be rated, the player must qualify for and compete in major disc golf tournaments. In December 2021, 60 players from the gender-protected women's division (FPO) and more than 100 players from the mixed or men's division (MPO) appeared in the index. To sample a matching number of men and women, the 60 highest ranked FPO and MPO players were selected. In the FPO division, three players had private accounts and one player had no account. These accounts were excluded from the sample, along with the four accounts from the MPO that matched the rankings of the missing FPO players. After these exclusions, there were a total of 112 players in the sample.

## Variables

Data were collected for all players to measure the independent variables. *Gender* was determined by whether the player competed in the gender-protected professional women's division (FPO) or in the mixed professional division where men play (MPO). *Dominance* scores were based on Udisc's Disc Golf World Ranking Index. Players were categorized by whether they were sponsored by one of three major equipment makers (*Big-3 Sponsor*). Innova, Discraft, and Prodigy were identified as the "big three," because they sponsored more players in the sample than other companies. Drawing on guidance from previous research (Agthe et al., 2011; Ohanian, 1990), a 10-point Likert-type scale ranging from 1 (unattractive) to 10 (very attractive) was used to measure the players' attractiveness. Two ratings, one for facial attractiveness and one for body attractiveness, were taken. The ratings were highly correlated ($r = .913$) and were therefore summed to measure overall *Attractiveness*. Following Gerding and Signorielli (2014), coders were asked to set aside their personal preferences and code players based on what would be considered attractive by most people in U.S. society. This conceptualization is consistent with expectation states theory, as the advantage of being attractive is thought to be rooted not in the coder's personal preference, but rather in the prevailing cultural standard or stereotype of beauty.

Six variables measured the self-branding behaviors of SMIs. Each player's total number of posts (*Total Posts*) and years of experience on Instagram (*Years on IG*) were recorded. In addition, four variables measured changes in self-branding over time. For these codes, the unit of analysis was the player's first 30 posts (Time 1) or 30 most recent posts on Instagram (Time 2). The measurement of each self-branding behavior was the number of posts out of 30 that contained the given behavior. If more than one photo or video appeared in a post, only the first image in the carousel was coded. Written captions and replies were not coded. Nine players posted fewer than 60 posts; for these players, their total number of posts was divided evenly into Time 1 and Time 2 posts (most of these players had between 40 and 59 posts). Inclusion of the nine cases with fewer than 60 posts did not affect the conclusions of this study. A total of 6240 posts were coded and aggregated by time period.

Following Woods et al. (2023), the first of the four self-branding variables was the number of photos or videos out of 30 that included the account holder in the image (*Player in Post*). The second variable was the number of posts that included any sign of disc golf, such as a disc golf course, any type of disc golf equipment, or a player throwing a disc (*Sport in Post*). The third variable was the number of posts that included at least one of the logos of the twelve companies that sponsored at least one player in the sample (*Brand in Post*). These companies included Innova, Discraft, Prodigy, Dynamic Discs, Dismania, Latitude 64, MVP, Westside, Gateway, Infinite Discs, Mint Discs, and DGA. Logos were commonly seen on the players' shirts and hats. The fourth variable was the number of posts that included a prominent display of a disc golf product (*Product Display*). Some cases of product display were overt, such an "in the bag" video where a player describes each of the discs they use during tournaments. Other product displays were subtler, as in the case where a player posts a photo of a sunset with their disc golf bag positioned at a focal point in the image.

As mentioned, each self-branding behavior was measured at Time 1 (first 30 posts) and Time 2 (30 most recent posts), allowing for a measurement of changes in the rate of self-branding over time. The four items of self-branding were subjected to principal components analyses, which revealed the presence of only one component with an eigenvalue that exceeded one in the results at Time 1 and Time 2. For this reason, the items were combined in a single index to measure the volume of self-branding at the two time periods. The two indexes had good internal consistency, with a Cronbach's alpha coefficients of .75 for Time 1 and .77 for Time 2. To measure changes in self-branding over time, a third index was computed by subtracting the volume of self-branding at Time 1 from the volume of self-branding at Time 2.

The dependent variables included the players' total number of followers (*Followers*), and a measure of engagement based on a third-party application that computed the mean number of likes on the players' last 12 posts (*Likes*).

### Coder Training and Reliability

Data for most variables (Gender, Dominance, Big-3 Sponsor, Total Posts, Years on IG) were gathered via secondary data collection. To measure attractiveness and changes in self-branding behaviors over time, three sociology PhD students received hourly pay to code the 112 players' Instagram accounts over a three-week period in January and February 2022. The demographic characteristics of the coders were diverse by age, race and gender. Before beginning the work, they attended four training sessions via zoom. Intercoder reliability tests of the four self-branding codes were conducted with 30 randomly selected accounts. Given that each account was analyzed at Time 1 and Time 2, a total of 60 units (1800 posts) were included in the tests. Following Riffe et al. (2005), Pearson's correlation coefficients were used to measure the consistency of the judgements of the coders—that is, whether their ratings varied together. Coefficients for the four variables were as follows: Player in Post (r = .96), Sport in Post (r = .94), Brand in Post (r = .93), and Product Display (r = .81). However, Krippendorff (2018) warned that consistency is not always the same as agreement when measuring the intercoder reliability of ratio-level variables. A two-way model for the intraclass correlation was used to further assess the reliability of the measures. The intraclass correlation coefficients were as follows: Player in post (r = .98), Sport in post (r = .97), Brand in post (r = .96), and Product display (r = .90). These values exceed common intercoder reliability standards (Cicchetti, 1994).

The intercoder reliability test for attractiveness was conducted on 74 of the 112 players in the sample. The Pearson correlation and intraclass correlation coefficients for face attractiveness were .58 and .73 respectively; the coefficients for body attractiveness were .51 and .68 respectively. These findings suggest moderate reliability, though caution should be used to interpret the validity of both face and body attractiveness (Cicchetti, 1994).

## Results

### Bivariate Analysis

Starting with a bivariate Pearson correlation analysis, most of the status characteristics were associated with social media popularity in the predicted directions. The players' dominance ratings and physical attractiveness were the two strongest positive predictors of popularity, as measured by follower counts and average likes (see Table 1). These findings provide support for Hypotheses 2 and 5. Attractiveness was a positive predictor of popularity for both men and women players. The correlation coefficient between attractiveness and followers for men (r = .390; $p < .01$) was similar to that of women (r = .446; $p < .01$); the correlation between attractiveness and likes for men (r = .474; $p < .01$) was also similar to that of women (r = .410; $p < .01$). As shown in Table 1, women (FPO) had fewer followers and likes than men (MPO). On average, women had 11,080 followers, while men had 28,039 followers; mean likes of women was 573 and

mean likes of men was 1548. These findings support Hypothesis 1. It should also be noted that women players shared 485 Instagram posts on average, 66% more than the men's average of 293 posts. Having a Big-3 Sponsor was slightly associated with being more popular, but the relationships were insignificant based on both followers and likes, which rejects Hypothesis 3 (see Table 1).

Self-branding behaviors were stronger predictors of follower counts than likes. As shown in Table 1, having more years of experience on Instagram and releasing more posts were significantly and positively associated with having more followers, but not with having more likes. Increases in three of the four self-branding behaviors between Time 1 and Time 2 were significant positive predictors of followers, but changes in the number of posts featuring the sport of disc golf (sport in post) was not a significant predictor of followers or likes. The uptake in Product Display was the only positive predictor of both followers and likes. The Self-Branding Index, a combined measure of changes in self-branding over time, was the strongest predictor of followers, but an insignificant predictor of likes (see Table 1). These data supported Hypothesis 4 in the case of follower counts, but not as it pertained to likes.

## *Multivariate Analysis*

Multiple regression analyses were conducted to further investigate the relationships found in the bivariate analyses and determine whether the status characteristics of SMIs predict their popularity when controlling for self-branding behaviors. The two measures of popularity, followers and likes, served as the dependent variables. The independent variables in each model included four measures of player status (gender, dominance, Big-3 sponsor, and attractiveness), and three measures of self-branding

**Table 1.** Pearson Correlations Between Status Characteristics and Self-Branding and Two Measures of Popularity.

| | Followers on Instagram | Likes on Instagram |
|---|---|---|
| Gender MPO = 0, FPO = 1 | −.283** | −.325*** |
| Dominance | .589*** | .481*** |
| Big-3 sponsor No = 0, Yes = 1 | .142 | .083 |
| Attractiveness | .348*** | .385*** |
| Total posts | .277** | .057 |
| Years on IG | .194* | .104 |
| Player in post (Δ) | .337*** | .127 |
| Sport in post (Δ) | .183 | .011 |
| Brand in post (Δ) | .252** | .126 |
| Product display (Δ) | .337*** | .233* |
| Self-branding index (Δ) | .374*** | .152 |

*Note.* $N = 112$, * = $p < .05$, ** = $p < .01$, *** = $p < .001$.

(total posts, years on IG, and changes in the self-branding index). In constructing the models, the assumptions (sample size, normality, linearity, and homoscedasticity) and potential shortcomings of regression (multicollinearity and outliers) were considered and found to be unproblematic. Three outliers were detected in the model used to predict follower counts, and two outliers were present in the model predicting likes, but these outliers did not require action, per Pallant (2013).

The first model explained 54% of the variance in followers, a respectable result compared to models appearing in similar published studies. Among status characteristics, player dominance, attractiveness, and gender contributed significantly to the explained variance in followers (see Table 2). Controlling for all other variables, players with stronger tournament performances (dominance) had more followers than players with weaker performances; attractive players had more followers than less attractive ones; and men had more followers than women. Having a Big-3 sponsorship was not a significant predictor of follower counts. These findings reinforced the conclusions of the bivariate analysis, adding support for Hypotheses 1, 2 and 5, and rejecting Hypothesis 3. Among self-branding behaviors, sharing more Instagram posts and increasing self-branding behaviors over time, as measured by the index, were significant positive predictors of followers, but having more years of experience on Instagram did not explain a meaningful amount of variance in followers (see Table 2). These results provide some support for Hypothesis 4 regarding the positive effects of self-branding on popularity.

The second model explained 41% of the variance in likes. The associations between players' status characteristics and likes were similar to those found in the model predicting followers. As shown in Table 2, dominance, attractiveness, and being a man were significant positive predictors of likes, and Big-3 sponsorship was not a significant predictor. However, the SMIs' total number of posts, years on Instagram, and self-branding index did not explain a significant amount of variance in likes.

**Table 2.** Regression Models Showing Standardized Regression Coefficients for Seven Predictors of Social Media Popularity.

| | Followers on instagram (Beta) | Likes on instagram (Beta) |
|---|---|---|
| Gender MPO = 0, FPO = 1 | −.222** | −.248** |
| Dominance | .493*** | .407*** |
| Big-3 sponsor No = 0, Yes = 1 | −.058 | −.074 |
| Attractiveness | .226** | .351*** |
| Total posts | .164* | −.042 |
| Years on IG | −.036 | .053 |
| Self-branding index (Δ) | .219** | .028 |
| R square | .544*** | .412*** |

*Note.* $N = 112$, * = $p < .05$, ** = $p < .01$, *** = $p < .001$.

## Discussion

In the 2010s, athletes from a range of sports increasingly turned to social media to reach their fans directly and construct of a public image to benefit their careers. Sports stars could now bypass the go-betweens of traditional media and share their journeys with a global community of likeminded enthusiasts. That a greater number of athletes from a broader range of sports were engaging their communities and building their brands online suggests that traditional power centers were fragmenting, and democratic pluralism was on the rise (Benkler, 2006; Hutchins & Rowe, 2013). The most optimistic version of this perspective assumes that all athletes can achieve success through hard work in the fields of competition and social media marketing. The underlying goal of this study was to critically evaluate this assumption.

We examined the Instagram accounts of 112 professional disc golfers to better understand how SMIs of lesser-known sports become popular on social media. The findings partially support the notion that SMIs can attract followers by performing well as both sport competitors and content creators. Controlling for all other factors, dominance in competitions was the strongest predictor of players' follower counts on Instagram. Top players like Kristin Tattar and Paul McBeth consistently had more followers than lower-rated players.

Savvy social media branding also appeared to pay off in online popularity. Supporting previous studies (Ashley & Tuten, 2015; Hopkins, 2013; Jensen et al., 2014; Watanabe et al., 2015), posting more content on social media was positively associated with follower counts based on bivariate and multivariate analyses. Increases in all four self-branding behaviors were positively correlated with followers, and the combined self-branding index was a significant predictor of follower counts, net of other variables. Over time, the most followed professional disc golfers on Instagram transformed their accounts from a mélange of images from everyday life to a more uniform set of posts, where their faces and bodies were increasingly present, where company logos were increasingly visible, and where branded equipment and other products were increasingly displayed. These findings may encourage athletes to invest greater resources in building their brands on social media, as the self-branding process appears to be a viable strategy for attracting followers, regardless of one's athletic performances and other status indicators (Lee & Theokary, 2021; Lim et al., 2021; Woods et al., 2023; Yesiloglu & Waskiw, 2021).

However, most measures of self-branding were not significant predictors of engagement. Posting more content was not associated with receiving more likes. On average, posts that included the player, sport or brand generated roughly the same number of likes as posts that did not include the player, sport or brand. Future studies should consider other self-branding techniques, such as running contests and incentives, asking questions in posts and responding to followers' replies, that may better predict engagement.

While the popularity of SMIs was predicted partly by their achievements in competitions and on social media, it was also predicted by their gender, an ascribed

quality assigned by others and shaped by society. Controlling for all other variables, women had significantly fewer followers and likes than men (see Table 2). These findings provide new insight on gender disparities in sports media. Previous research has shown that men's sports receive more coverage than women's sports in traditional media outlets, such as newspapers and television networks (Fink & Kensicki, 2002; Cooky et al., 2013; Cooky et al., 2015). There is some evidence that social media can be utilized by women athletes and women's sports organizations to counterbalance this lack of traditional media attention (Toffoletti et al., 2021; Vann, 2014). Social media platforms like Instagram and Twitter are allowing women to become part of the discussion of sports in ways that are often more meaningful and potentially transformative to women's sport communities than what is typically found in mainstream sports media (Sanderson & Gramlich, 2016).

In the case of professional women's disc golf, however, the stark inequalities seen in traditional media can also be found on social media. The long-standing cultural hierarchies of sport dominance and gender were clearly reflected in players' abilities to attract large followings on Instagram and develop revenue streams around their personal brands. Per expectation states theory, structural inequality at the macro level impacts individual evaluations of women athletes on social media, which reflect and reproduce the status structures that privilege men athletes and disadvantage women athletes (Correll & Ridgeway, 2006). On average, men had more than twice the number of followers and three times higher engagement rates than women, yet women created and shared 66% more posts on Instagram than men. More research is needed to determine whether these disparities are specific to disc golf or generalizable to other sports.

Physical attractiveness, another ascribed characteristic, also explained some of the variance in popularity among professional disc golfers on Instagram. Based on a measure of perceived stereotypical beauty in the US context, having an attractive face and body boosted the reach and engagement of SMIs, even when controlling for all other variables. These findings support previous research showing that attractive people receive advantages in a wide variety of face-to-face contexts (Frevert & Walker, 2014; Webster & Driskell, 1983; Wolbring & Riordan, 2016), as well as on social media (Wiedmann & von Mettenheim, 2020; Essi et al., 2019; Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017; VonMettenheim & Wiedmann, 2021).

## Contributions and Limitations

This study contributes to the literature on influencer marketing in two ways. First, most previous studies can be read as how-to guides for reaching and engaging audiences online. For instance, as discussed in three review essays on influencer marketing (Hudders et al., 2021; Sundermann & Raabe, 2019; Vrontis et al., 2021), SMIs can attract and engage followers by using emotional language, posting content with high media vividness, encouraging followers to interact, fostering parasocial relationships, and several other communication strategies. This study offers a counterbalance to the

agency-focused literature, as it shows how the popularity of SMIs depends not only on what they do and say, but also on whether they possess privileged status characteristics. Second, this study demonstrates how expectation states theory can be used as a framework for considering how inequalities emerge in sports communities as their members gather on social media and designate the most popular leaders. By mining this empirically rich, decades-old research program, influencer marketing scholars may identify a host of status characteristics that convey advantages to those SMIs who possess them.

The main limitation of this study is its inability to formally test expectation states theory and identify the social psychological mechanism that explains the variance in social media popularity. In addition to theories of social status, future studies should consider alternative perspectives that offer similar predictions. For instance, homophily preferences are a cognitive bias that leads people to forge friendships and establish social networks with people who are like them (Smith-Lovin & McPherson, 1993; McPherson et al., 2001). If a preference for racial, gender, or age similarity affects how social media users choose who to follow, the popularity of SMIs would be shaped not by cultural beliefs about competence, but rather by the prevailing demographics of an online community. Given that some sports are played and spectated more so by men than women, preferences for gender similarity may give men athletes an advantage over women athletes in the sphere of influencer marketing (Gupta et al., 2022; Hudders & De Jans, 2022; Roth, 2004). In the case of disc golf, an estimated 85% of players are men (Woods, 2019).

Alternative perspectives may explain the effects of attractiveness as well. People may be more likely to follow attractive SMIs than less attractive SMIs because of personal factors such as self-gratification, romantic fantasy, or sexual appeal, as opposed to an unconscious assumption that what is beautiful is good. It should also be noted that developing a consistent measurement of the SMIs' physical attractiveness was challenging. The intercoder reliability for this variable was sufficient but lower than the reliability of other measures. Future studies may benefit from developing more specific and manifest codes for measuring beauty as a status characteristic.

We should emphasize that expectation states theory offers a limited explanation of gender inequality in SMI popularity. The theory does not account for gender-based pay gaps in salaries and sponsorship money, the lack of women in high positions in the sports industry, or media attention that favors men athletes (Woods, 2021). The differences in popularity among professional men and women disc golfers on Instagram may simply be the result of gender disparities in funding and promotional efforts. Given its focus on non-conscious psychological processes, expectation states theory also cannot explain the history of intentional sexism, prejudice, and discrimination against women in sports, including disc golf (Woods, 2021).

## Conclusion

The goal of this study was to explain the variance in popularity among athlete SMIs. Most previous studies of influencer marketing assume that SMIs themselves have the power to attract and engage followers through self-branding and other forms of strategic communication (Hudders et al., 2021; Sundermann & Raabe, 2019; Vrontis et al., 2021). Based on the case of professional disc golfers on Instagram, our findings provided some evidence in favor of this agency-focused literature. SMIs on Instagram who posted often and engaged in self-branding tended to have more followers than those who posted less frequently and exhibited fewer signs of self-branding. Achieving success in professional disc golf tournaments also carried over to success on social media. The Instagram accounts of top players tended to have greater reach and engagement rates than those of lower-ranked players. These findings suggest that hard work pays off, and that achieved status predicts popularity online.

However, drawing on sociological theories of social status, we also showed that the gender and attractiveness of SMIs were associated with their ability to reach and engage followers online. Being a man or beautiful gave SMIs an advantage in the influencer marketplace above and beyond their achievements in competition and content creation. More research is needed to determine whether these patterns can be found in the online social networks of other sports. Future studies should also consider the possible effects of other status characteristics, such as race, ethnicity, class, sexuality, and religion. Studies of the lived experiences of SMIs and the economic, social, and psychological consequences of self-branding are also in demand.

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